

Pseudoscience on the Margin

Wrong-about-reality claims with no hidden-villain spine — except the spine quietly reappears in the language of the claims themselves.

SignalWatch · Pseudoscience report · 14 theories across 4 domains of science

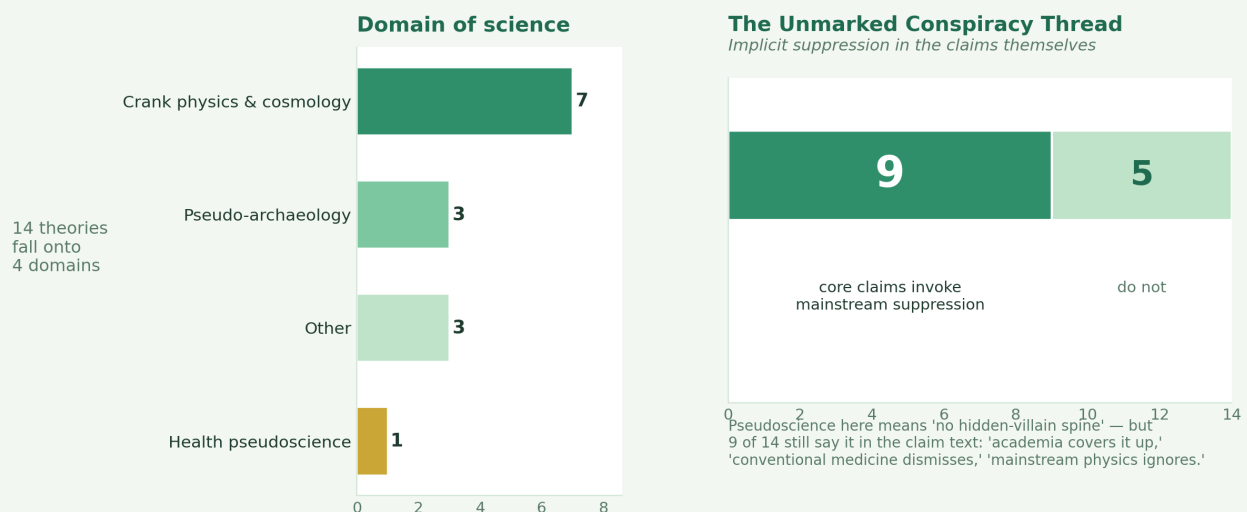
Pseudoscience is the SignalWatch shelf next door to conspiracy theories. It catches claims that *look* like science but get reality wrong — crank physics, pseudo-archaeology, fringe-cosmology, junk-health devices — without the central malevolent-actor spine of a true conspiracy theory. The cut SignalWatch makes is unambiguous: a theory with a hidden villain causing or covering up harm (chemtrails spraying, anti-vax, directed-energy attacks, suppressed-cancer plots) stays a conspiracy theory even when it misuses science. Pseudoscience is the residual — the theories where *the wrong claim is the point, not a villain*. 14 of them, today, across four domains of science.

That definition is mechanical: scanner-flagged (the A2 marker battery — physical-law violations, predatory venues, Galileo-gambit rhetoric) **and** no A1 conspiratorial-spine. But mechanical doesn't mean clean. The same 14 theories that pass the A1=false filter overwhelmingly invoke *mainstream suppression* in their core claims: academia is covering it up; conventional medicine dismisses; mainstream physics ignores; the energy industry suppresses. This paper is about that paradox, about where these theories live, and about what's missing from how we currently catch them.

1 · A shelf next door

The Pseudoscience Shelf, by Kind

14 theories flagged by the A2 marker battery — wrong-about-reality claims, no hidden-villain spine.



SignalWatch · Pseudoscience report · pseudoscience theories that don't have a hidden-villain spine, but lean on a mainstream-suppression frame · thesignalwatcher.com

Figure 1 — the 14 pseudoscience theories by domain of science, and how many lean on a mainstream-suppression frame in the claims themselves.

The promotion path from conspiracy-theory to pseudoscience is explicit. Every theory in the SignalWatch corpus is classified along two independent axes: **A1** (is there a hidden malevolent actor causing or covering up harm?) and **A2** (is the core a wrong-about-reality claim — crank physics, free energy, fringe cosmology, pseudo-archaeology?). The four quadrants of the A1×A2 space carry different labels:

- **A1=true · A2=true** — conspiratorial pseudoscience. Stays in the main conspiracy-theory shelf. (Chemtrails, anti-vax, directed-energy attacks: the science is wrong AND there's a named villain inflicting harm.)
- **A1=true · A2=false** — pure conspiracy theory. The villain frame doesn't depend on a physics violation. (Election fraud, Epstein, Great Replacement, the deep state.)
- **A1=false · A2=true** — pseudoscience. **The 14 theories in this paper.** Wrong about reality, but the wrongness is the point — no villain inflicting active harm.
- **A1=false · A2=false** — neither flagged. Most of the corpus.

The classifier treats the A1=false filter as a hard gate. A theory that explicitly names a villain inflicting harm — Big Pharma suppressing cancer cures, the energy industry murdering inventors — gets promoted back into the conspiracy-theory shelf, no matter how badly it abuses physics. What sits on the pseudoscience shelf, then, is the set of theories that fail to clear that bar for a hidden malevolent actor *and yet* still talk like they're being suppressed by one. The right panel of Figure 1 is the headline finding of this paper: **9 of the 14 theories** on the pseudoscience shelf invoke mainstream suppression in their core claims anyway. The villain exited through the door marked A1, then climbed back in through the rhetoric.

2 • Four domains of science

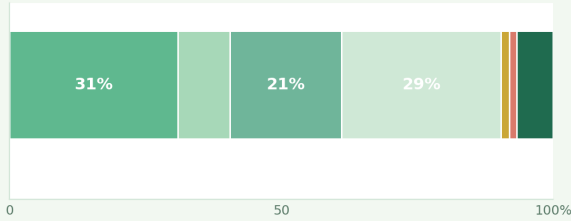
The 14 theories drop onto four domains, with crank physics doing most of the work. The taxonomy isn't subtle — physical-law violation is the load-bearing A2 marker, and physics is where most of those violations live. But the venue mix differs by domain in instructive ways, and the story isn't only about physics:

- **Crank physics & cosmology (7 theories).** Gravity-denial — both flavors (gravity as an internal atomic force; gravity as density-and-buoyancy) — plus Flat Earth, Simulation Theory, Vortex Math & the Rodin Coil, Suppressed Free Energy Machines, and the Barron Trump Time Travel conspiracy. Several of these are perfectly good candidates for the A1=true shelf (free-energy inventors are explicitly 'suppressed by the energy industry') but the harm being inflicted is ambiguous enough to fall on this side of the line.
- **Pseudo-archaeology (3 theories).** Beneath the Pyramids (Giza tunnels, allegedly suppressed by 'mainstream institutions'), Elongated Skulls (the Nephilim explanation, 'academia and museums covering up'), Phantom Time Hypothesis (no AD 614–911 happened). The threat level here drifts upward — one of these is the only *elevated* threat-rated pseudoscience theory in the corpus.
- **Health pseudoscience (1 theory).** Quantum Frequency and Scalar Healing Devices — Spooky2 Scalar, terahertz Tesla wands, products that 'conventional medicine dismisses.' This is a sparse domain in this corpus because the high-harm health-conspiracy theories (anti-vax, suppressed cancer cures, 5G-causes-COVID) all pass the A1 gate and end up filed as conspiracy theories.
- **Other (3 theories).** The Bulga Sphere (mystery metal, possibly alien), Baba Vanga's hantavirus prophecy, the 2026 Digital Simulation Sync Phenomenon. These don't fit the three established domains, but score the A2 markers anyway.

Four Domains, Four Venue Mixes

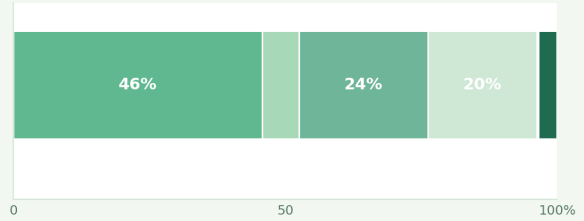
How presentation differs by what's being claimed. Each panel: aggregate share of sources for theories in that domain.

Crank physics & cosmology (7 theories · 668 items)



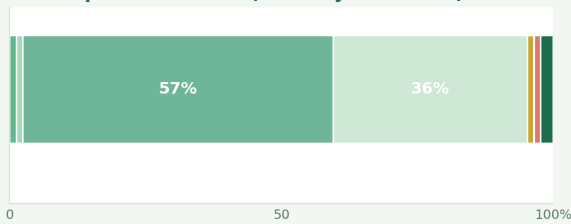
Barron Trump Time Travel Conspiracy, Flat Earth, Gravity Is an Internal Atomic Force, +4 more

Pseudo-archaeology (3 theories · 295 items)



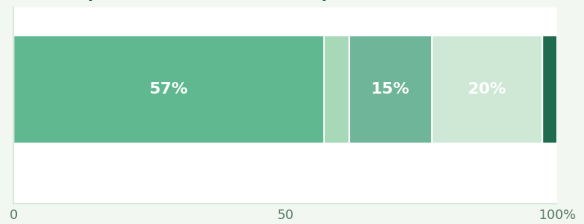
Beneath the Pyramids, Elongated Skulls, Phantom Time Hypothesis

Health pseudoscience (1 theory · 84 items)



Quantum Frequency and Scalar Healing

Other (3 theories · 217 items)



2026 Digital Simulation Sync Phenom, Baba Vanga 2026 Predictions & Hanta, Bulga Sphere

■ short video ■ social / forum ■ podcast ■ long-form blog ■ marketing ■ crank paper ■ reference

Figure 2 — venue mix by domain. Crank physics travels through more diverse venues (more marketing tail, more reference rebuttal). Archaeology concentrates in short video. Health pseudoscience lives almost entirely in two media.

What the per-domain panels make visible — and the aggregate bar in the next figure foreshadows — is that pseudoscience doesn't have one presentation style. It has roughly four, in different mixes.

3 · The professionalism spectrum

Where Pseudoscience Lives — the Professionalism Spectrum

Aggregating sources across all 14 theories, by formality of presentation venue.

All sources combined · n = 1,264 content items



short video social / forum podcast long-form blog marketing crank paper reference
YouTube TikTok Rumble Reddit X Gab Apple Podcasts Medium Substack Etsy Amazon Scribd Academia.edu Wikipedia BBC

Per-theory mix · sorted by share of formal-looking venues

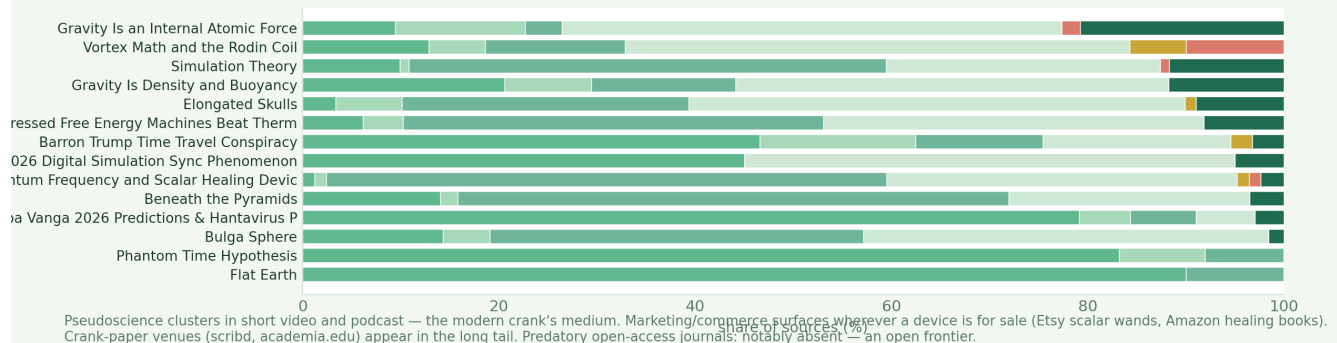


Figure 3 — where pseudoscience claims live, by formality of presentation venue. The aggregate bar reads left-to-right from informal to formal; the per-theory mix below shows how each theory's source mix actually distributes.

Pseudoscience comes in different presentational *register* — the user-facing format the claim is wrapped in. A 90-second Flat Earth TikTok and a 30-page self-published 'unified field theory' PDF are arguing the same thing, but they trade for different things. The TikTok wants reach; the PDF wants the patina of seriousness. SignalWatch tracks where the harvested content actually lives, which gives a rough map of that spectrum:

- **Short video** (YouTube, TikTok, Rumble, BitChute) — the modern crank's medium. 37% of all sources. The format does most of the work: fast cuts, voice-over, no peer review, no citations, instant share.
- **Podcast** (Apple Podcasts, the listener-facing index) — 23%. Long-form interview discussions on shows whose hosts range across the political spectrum but tend to lean credulous on fringe-science guests.
- **Marketing / commerce** (Etsy, Amazon, books.apple.com) — 26%. The tell-tale signal of a pseudoscience that has crossed from ideology into **product**. Quantum scalar healing wands. Vortex-math coils. Lost-civilization books. When a theory has a sale page, the seller has skin in the game.
- **Social / forum** (Reddit, X, Gab, knowyourmeme) — 8%. Lower than you'd expect, because the political-conspiracy theories dominate that register.
- **Long-form blog** (Medium, Substack, personal sites) — appearing in the long tail. The format for the wannabe-essay version of the claim.

- **Crank paper / preprint** (Scribd, Academia.edu, ResearchGate) — a thin slice. The self-published 'paper' venues are where someone who wants to look serious puts the PDF.
- **Reference / news** (Wikipedia, BBC, Scientific American) — almost exclusively debunks. When the establishment shows up on a pseudoscience theory's page, it's usually rebutting the claim, not endorsing it.

Two patterns that aren't obvious from the aggregate

First, **physics is the most multi-register** domain. Where archaeology is concentrated in short video and health in video-plus-marketing, the physics-flavored theories spread across video, marketing (Spooky2 wands), long-form blog (gravity-denial explainers), and the thin crank-paper tail. The more elaborate the claimed mechanism, the more registers it has to live in to be argued — you can show a video of an object falling, but you need a long-form blog to claim what gravity actually *is*.

Second, **marketing is the cleanest signal that a theory has commercial tailwinds**. Quantum Frequency / Scalar Healing Devices is a product ecosystem; the marketing share is enormous because the theory *is* the sales pitch. Suppressed Free Energy is its mirror image at the other end of physics: no product to sell yet, almost no marketing share, mostly video and podcast.

4 • The unmarked conspiracy thread

The Unmarked Conspiracy Thread

Suppression language in the core claims — pseudoscience here means 'no hidden-villain spine,' but the spine reappears rhetorically.

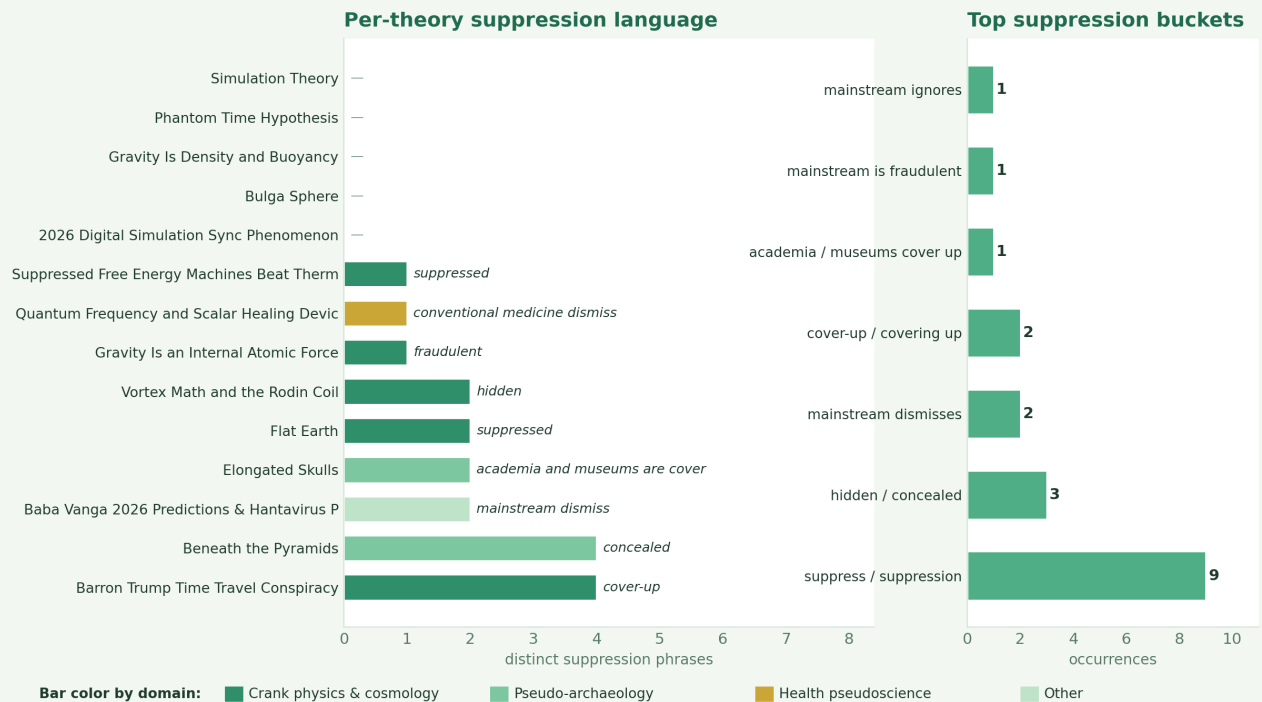


Figure 4 — implicit suppression language in the 14 theories' core claims. Left: which theories carry the language, and what the strongest phrase is. Right: the most-invoked suppression buckets across the corpus.

This is the most uncomfortable finding in the report. The pseudoscience shelf is defined as *not* having a hidden malevolent-actor spine — that's what the A1=false gate enforces — but the rhetoric of *mainstream suppression* is everywhere in the claims:

"Mainstream institutions are working to suppress or restrict access." (Beneath the Pyramids)

"Academia and museums are covering up the evidence — restricting access, closing exhibits 'for renovation,' suppressing DNA results." (Elongated Skulls)

"Free-energy inventors are suppressed by the energy industry to protect oil and utility profits." (Suppressed Free Energy Machines)

"Mainstream mathematics and physics ignore vortex math because it overturns their established understanding." (Vortex Math & the Rodin Coil)

"Conventional medicine dismisses [the device]'s energetic signature." (Quantum Frequency and Scalar Healing Devices)

Across the 14 theories, **9 of 14** use this language in their core claims. The pattern is consistent: it isn't a named industry suppressing it for a named reason, which is what the A1 filter is looking for. It's **'mainstream X'** — mainstream science, mainstream medicine, mainstream institutions, academia — performing a diffuse, structural refusal-to-look. The acting subject is an establishment, not an agent. That's

exactly the seam where the A1 classifier can let a theory through: there's no specific 'they' with a specific motive, only the establishment's collective indifference. Rhetorically, though, the believer doesn't experience that distinction. *They* are still hiding it. The theory is still about being right while a powerful institution refuses to acknowledge it.

What this means for the labels

It would be wrong to conclude that pseudoscience is just conspiracy theory with one less dimension. The A1 distinction is real and useful — the theories that name a villain inflicting *harm* behave differently from those that don't, both in how they spread and in what they ask believers to do. Anti-vaccine theories produce measles outbreaks; the claim that 'mainstream physics ignores vortex math' produces YouTube videos. The labels are doing useful work.

But the boundary is rhetorically **porous**. A pseudoscience theory that develops a more pointed villain — naming a specific industry, alleging a specific concealment — promotes back across the A1 gate into the main conspiracy-theory shelf. The Suppressed Free Energy theory is the case to watch: it already names the energy industry as the suppressor; one more step (a named harm, a named victim) and it stops being pseudoscience and starts being a conspiracy theory about murdered inventors. The pseudoscience shelf is, in part, a queue.

5 · An open frontier — the venues we're not yet scanning

One thing the venue mix in Figures 2 and 3 makes visible is **what isn't there**. The 'crank paper / preprint' slice — Scribd, Academia.edu, ResearchGate — is real but small, mostly arrived at indirectly through web search. **Predatory open-access journals** — the pay-to-publish venues on Beall's list, OMICS-pattern sites, single-editor 'International Journal of ...' shells — are essentially absent from this corpus.

That isn't because the claims aren't published in those venues. It's because the SignalWatch ingest path doesn't yet scan them. The R4 predatory-venue marker fires on URLs we encounter, but we don't go to those URLs first looking for our 14 theories. **viXra** — the self-described 'open archive for crank physics' — almost certainly has every gravity-denial theory we track, plus more we haven't found. Predatory-journal aggregates would surface the health-pseudoscience long tail. Self-published-book platforms (lulu, smashwords) would surface the lost-civilization archaeology corpus.

Adding those venues isn't free — the predatory landscape changes weekly, Beall's list isn't authoritative, and ingest needs the R4 marker to actually downweight rather than amplify. But the gap is visible from what's already in the corpus. A theory like *Gravity Is an Internal Atomic Force* showing only a thin video-and-blog footprint almost certainly has a richer crank-paper presence the harvest hasn't reached yet. The next iteration of the pseudoscience shelf should:

- Add a **crank-archive harvester** targeting viXra, ResearchGate (with predatory-venue R4 score), and Academia.edu — same atom path, but the source-domain pre-classifies the formality register.
- Add a **predatory-journal classifier** bootstrapped from Beall's list (historical) plus current pay-to-publish flags, scoring R4 on ingest.
- Treat **'mainstream X suppresses'** as its own marker, scored on core_claims and atom text — the seam we found here should fire as a feature, not just appear in retrospective analysis.
- Watch the queue: a pseudoscience theory whose suppression language sharpens — names a specific industry or specific harm — should auto-promote back to the conspiracy-theory shelf with a flagged transition.

Closing

The pseudoscience shelf is doing what it was built to do — catching the claims that abuse the form of science without the harm-doing spine of a conspiracy theory — and the catch is honest. The discomfort is that the underlying rhetorical frame is shared. Conspiracy theories and pseudoscience both promise the believer that they see what the establishment refuses to. The difference is whether 'the establishment' is a named villain or a diffuse institution. The 14 theories on this shelf are reaching for the villain frame with one hand while the other hand holds them back — and that strain is, itself, one of the more instructive things the corpus can show.

This paper covers 14 pseudoscience theories tracked by SignalWatch as of June 2026, on the pastel-green Pseudoscience shelf at thesignalwatcher.com/pseudoscience. The A1/A2 classifier and the promotion path are documented in `epistemic_deviance_build.md` (SignalWatch internal). Source data and the controlled vocabularies are available on the Data page. © SignalWatch — free to use with attribution.